

THE HOMELAND BATTLE

The Government scores a crucial political victory in the Eastern Provincial Council elections after militarily ousting the Tamil Tigers from what they considered as their unified homeland

AFP PHOTO



■ By Christine Jaysinghe in Colombo

After making significant military gains over the Tamil Tigers, the Sri Lankan Government is now working towards defanging them politically too. After successfully dislodging the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE) from their stranglehold over the Eastern province of the country, President Mahinda Rajapakse moved quickly to consolidate the Government's hold over the critical province. He first announced large-scale development programmes for the key districts of Trincomalee, Batticaloa and Ampara. Then despite warnings about stepped-up terror attacks and rigged ballots, the Government went ahead last week with elections for the Eastern Provincial Council.

For LTTE, the Eastern Provincial Council puts paid to the idea of a con-

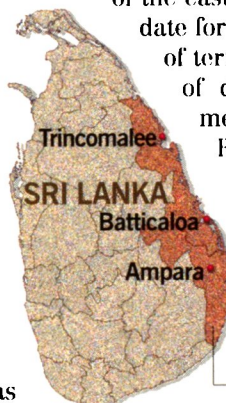
joined north and east which has been their starting point in political negotiations. The merger was the key provision of the 1987 Indo-Lanka accord through which New Delhi tried to ensure some measure of power would devolve on Tamils here. Although regional elections for a North-east Provincial Council in 1988 installed a pro-Indian, Tamil chief minister, Varathrajah Perumal, he lasted a brief two years in office. He fled to India after unilaterally declaring independence and his own armed faction was clobbered by LTTE. Last year, the two provinces were legally de-linked by the Supreme Court on a petition filed by the radical Janatha Vimukthi Peramuna which wants LTTE trounced in the battlefield. Meanwhile, the Government was

DEMOCRACY AT WORK: A woman casts her vote in Trincomalee

able to dislodge LTTE militarily from the east and confine the Tigers' writ only to the North of Sri Lanka.

Importantly for the Government, the ruling United Peoples Freedom Alliance (UPFA) won a majority in the Eastern Provincial polls. "The people of the east have given a clear mandate for peace through the defeat of terrorism, the strengthening of democracy and development of the country,"

Rajapakse said after the results were in. Experts believe that holding elections in an area claimed by the Tamil Tigers as part of its independent homeland



EASTERN PROVINCE